> sense of the queries of the coloniser, Indians learned to use English-language words (‘religion’, ‘revelation’, ‘God’, ‘worship’, ‘priest’, ‘idolatry’), without having access to the background theology that related these terms to each other in a systematic way.
>
> For instance, while puja rituals are not in any sense the equivalent of worship in Christianity, Europeans misunderstood these rituals as worship and mistranslated ‘puja’ as ‘worship’. In the next step, Indians learned English and accepted that ‘worship’ meant ‘puja’, without understanding what worship is in Christianity and without having access to the linguistic practices and conceptual schemes, which related this notion of worship to other theological concepts like God, idolatry and religion. Given our current lack of insight into this process, we cannot grasp the distortions that occurred when the term ‘worship’ was mapped onto ‘puja’.
>
> A similar process occurred for all such appropriations of English-language terms and theological notions. As Indians took over these words, their original meanings were distorted, accordingly as European-language terms were mapped onto terms and semantic schemes from Indian languages (e.g., ‘dharma’, ‘apaurusheya’, ‘deva’, ‘puja’, ‘purohit’, ‘murtipuja’).

This extract succinctly highlights the problematic use of Christian colonial linguistics or semantics and the underlying Protestant experience to describe and understand Indic systems, institutions and practices, which results in the superimposition of the Christian framework on native consciousness. In this regard, once again the Shirur Math Judgment is useful to demonstrate the way Indian constitutional courts have applied Christian colonial linguistics to Indic institutions and practices.

In the Shirur Math Judgment, apart from setting out the ERP test based on the religious versus secular divide, the Supreme Court also laid down the criteria for what constitutes a ‘religious denomination’ under Article 26, which is the law on this issue to date. Here is the relevant excerpt from the judgment:

> *As regards article 26, the first question is, what is the precise meaning or connotation of the expression ‘religious denomination’ and whether a Math could come within this expression. The word ‘denomination’*